CAREER GLITCH · SHORT · SIMPLE · NO BORING PARTS

SPECIAL EDUCATION TEACHER IN THE AI ERA

Every plan is custom, every kid is a puzzle — the least automatable classroom there is.

★ TL;DR — Special education at a ~$67K median, on a bachelor's plus state licence road — the shortest degree-gated licence in this batch. The shortage is the story: 48 states plus Puerto Rico and DC project one, and ~37,100 openings appear every year despite 0% headline growth. The catch is unchanged: paperwork is a second job hiding inside the first. ★

THE CAREER GLITCH TAKE

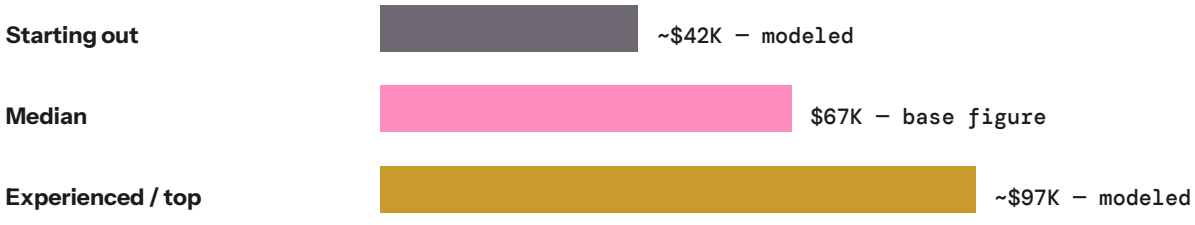
OUR TAKE: YES

MEDIAN ~$67K · TRAINING 2-4 years · AI RISK LOW · STATE LICENSE

- The hardest seat in American education to fill: 74% of elementary and middle schools couldn't fill a special-ed vacancy with a fully certified teacher (NCES).
- Pay correction: the median is $67,170, not $75K — beginners land in the biggest sub-groups (elementary $65,120, preschool $64,830), with a bottom decile under $49,230.
- AI relieves the worst task instead of taking the job: 57% of special-ed teachers used AI for IEPs and 504 plans in 2024–25 — drafting help for a legal document the licensed teacher still owns.

The site's take, built from this profession's numbers in the Career Glitch base.

THE MONEY — LOOK AT THE BARS



The Career Glitch base figure for Special Education Teacher is a ~$67K median (compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). The starting and top

bars are modeled around that median — orientation, not a promise. Pay swings hard by state, employer and experience: check live postings in your state before planning around any number.

WHAT DOES A SPECIAL EDUCATION TEACHER ACTUALLY DO?

- ✓ Writing and running individualized education programs (IEPs)
- ✓ Adapting lessons and teaching in small groups or co-taught classes
- ✓ Tracking behavior and progress data for each student
- ✓ Meetings with families, general teachers and specialists

Think: part teacher, part case manager, part translator between a child and the system.

WHAT AI ALREADY TOOK (AND WHAT IT CAN'T)

THE ROBOT	THE HUMAN
IEP goal drafts, progress-note wording, adapted materials. The output is a first draft for a document with legal force — a licensed teacher reviews it, signs it and answers for it.	Assessment, adaptation and advocacy for one named child, in person, under a federal mandate (IDEA). The caseload is a list of legal entitlements, not a queue software can clear.

⚠ **THE HONEST COSTS: attrition runs at nearly twice the general-education rate, roughly 10 hours a week of paperwork happens outside the school day, and the bottom decile starts under $49,230. The shortage makes you hireable, not comfortable — choose your district and your mentor like they decide whether you stay. They do.**

THE VIBE — IS THIS YOUR LIFE?

THE JOB IS	THE JOB IS NOT
✓ Wins measured in millimeters that matter enormously ✓ Districts competing for you before graduation ✓ AI drafting the paperwork you used to dread	✗ A compliance calendar that never empties ✗ Emotional weight most days ✗ Meetings about the work compete with the work

Good fit? Patient, observant, stubbornly organized — and you light up at progress other people can't see.
Bad fit? You want a predictable desk rhythm, or paperwork makes you quit things.

THE FORK — PICK ONE DOOR

DOOR A — EDUCATION DEGREE WITH SPECIAL-ED ENDORSEMENT	DOOR B — PARAEDUCATOR TO TEACHER

The direct road: a bachelor's with a special-education major or endorsement, student teaching, state exams, licence. The demand side is extreme — ~55,000 special-ed positions vacant and ~270,000 more filled by teachers not fully qualified (CEC/CASE) — so districts recruit from your program before you graduate. First move: pick a program whose placements sit in districts you'd actually work for.	Work as a special-ed paraprofessional while you finish the bachelor's: paid classroom time, a front-row view of IEPs, and a district that already trusts you with its hardest rooms. Many districts run para-to-teacher pipelines and tuition support for exactly this seat. First move: apply for para roles in your target district and ask about its tuition pipeline on day one.

Smart move: Do your field placements where you want to be hired. Special-ed hiring is a reputation game, and your reputation is built in someone else's classroom.
Where you land after: Special-education lead, inclusion specialist, or district-level coordination roles.

YOUR ROADMAP — 6 STEPS

1	2	3	4	5	6
MAP THE	ENTER THE	WORK INSIDE	STUDENT TEACHING	LICENSE EXAMS	TAKE YOUR

STEP 1 — Map the license and specialty

FREE · TODAY

- Your state's gate: bachelor's + special-ed certification + exams + background check; a master's is not an entry requirement
- Choose your level: elementary and preschool are the biggest, lowest-paid sub-groups; secondary medians $74,260

STEP 2 — Enter the degree path

TUITION · YEAR 1

- An accredited special-education program; alternative certification exists in all states if you already hold a bachelor's
- Take a paraprofessional job alongside if money is tight — it's paid field experience

STEP 3 — Work inside real classrooms

YEARS 1-2

- Placements in special-ed settings, not general classrooms
- Learn the IEP calendar: evaluations, annual reviews, progress data

STEP 4 — Student teaching in special education

YEAR 2-3

- A full caseload semester under a mentor teacher
- Practise the paperwork discipline — about 10 hours a week of it happens outside the school day

STEP 5 — License exams and application

LICENSE · FINAL YEAR

- Pass the general and subject tests; clear the background check
- File the licence application; shortage-area postings open before you graduate

STEP 6 — Take your first caseload

FINAL MONTHS

- Apply where the vacancy lists are — 74% of elementary and middle schools struggled to fill this seat certified
- Negotiate caseload support and mentor time, not just the salary step

FIRST 90 DAYS — JUST DO THIS

- □ Today: your state's special-ed licence checklist, plus three districts' vacancy pages.
- □ Days 1–30: program or alt-cert route chosen; para application filed if you need income now.
- □ Days 31–60: coursework started; first special-ed classroom hours logged.
- □ Days 61–90: placement school set; the IEP process observed end to end once.
- □ Day 90: you're in the pipeline for the seat schools cannot fill — with classroom hours already banked.

NEXT — MAKE IT PERSONAL

This roadmap is the same for everyone. Your life is not.

- Not sure this career fits YOU? Take the Big Career Test — 50 questions, your top-3 matches and one honest “probably NOT you”. → careerglitch.com/#test
- Already sure? Turn AI into Your Personal Career Mentor — a 2,300-word system that interviews you first, checks your hours, budget and deadline honestly, and builds YOUR plan into a Notion dashboard. → careerglitch.com/#prompt

★ **PROGRESS IS MEASURED IN MILLIMETERS.** ★

CAREER GLITCH · Figures: Career Glitch profession base (medians and training ranges compiled from U.S. Bureau of Labor Statistics, Occupational Outlook Handbook ranges). Modeled bars are estimates around the base median. License and certification rules vary by state — verify with your state board before paying for any program.